



OIL ON THE BOIL

With volatility in crude oil prices continuing, any relief for the consumer is unlikely. Despite a steep excise duty cut, inflation, fiscal deficit and trade deficit remain a worry. The impact of high oil prices is visible in a depreciating rupee. The Opec forecast on demand crossing pre-pandemic levels and fresh US sanctions on Iran will ensure fickleness in oil prices for some time.

—MANISH PANT

AMERICAN INFLUENCE

Putting an end to all speculation, the US Fed went for an aggressive rate hike of 0.75 per cent, the biggest hike in the past 28 years, to tame inflation. The Fed, while announcing the rate hike, said it is “strongly committed” to returning inflation to 2 per cent. It also projected a slowing of the US economy. Such aggressive monetary policy has ramifications for India, too. It could spook investors in India’s stock markets, and also lead to more FPIs pulling out, and lead to further depreciation in the rupee’s value. That, in



turn, would stoke inflation further, which is already above the Reserve Bank of India’s target band of 2-6 per cent.

—RAJAT MISHRA

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VIKRAM HAASAN

It has been quite a comeback for Kamal Haasan. After a forgettable political debut, he is back to what he does best. *Vikram*, an action thriller and the actor’s first film in almost four years, has set the cash registers ringing. Made on a budget of ₹170 crore, its box-office collection has gone past ₹300 crore globally. Produced by Haasan, the pre-sale satellite, digital, theatrical and distribution rights, among others, raked in ₹200 crore. Guess who is smiling the most these days?

—KRISHNA GOPALAN

Watch Out for Those...

ARMED WITH a new set of guidelines and a nodal body to scrutinise unfair promotional campaigns, the consumer affairs ministry is tightening the noose around companies that resort to misleading advertisements. Since the formation of the Central Consumer Protection Authority in 2021, the body has issued 120 notices, forcing 14 firms to withdraw their ads. Companies like Naaptol and Sure Vision India have been penalised ₹10 lakh each for misleading ads. Over the past six months, apparel brands Zodiak and Siyaram’s, Asian Paints, Berger Paints, Lifebuoy from HUL, Kent RO and Century Ply were forced to withdraw ads claiming respite from Covid-19.

—ARNAB DUTTA

...MISLEADING ADVERTISEMENTS

Celebrities may be forced to take a long, hard look at what they choose to advertise. The new, legally binding guidelines set by the consumer affairs ministry say they need to declare their stakes in the brands they endorse and that their endorsement

“must be based on adequate information about, or experience with the identified goods, product or service”. Violators face a ₹10-50 lakh fine and can be prohibited from making any endorsement for three years.

—VIDYA S.



LAKH CRORE PROVISIONAL BANK CREDIT TO MICRO, SMALL AND MEDIUM ENTERPRISES IN 2021-22. THE FIGURE WAS ₹17.84 LAKH CRORE IN FY21